

Designer's Note: Five Choices in This Lesson

BRANDON GLUCK, ON *TENUOUS THREADS* BY JUDY ABRAMS

Every lesson is a stack of decisions, and most of them are invisible by the time the page is finished. I want to make five of mine visible here, because the decisions are the lesson. The layout, the typography, the curriculum codes do not carry the work. The five below are the ones I would defend across a table if someone asked me, “why this and not that?”

1 SINGLE PASSAGE, NOT MEMOIR OVERVIEW.

I considered a four-lesson arc that ran across the whole memoir: prewar Budapest, the convent, liberation, Montreal. I chose one passage instead. A Grade 6 student who learns to read one Holocaust memoir passage closely will be better prepared to read the next one than a student who has surveyed four passages thinly. The USC Shoah Foundation's IWitness model works the same way: a carefully selected testimony excerpt, paired with explicit historical context, sat with long enough to actually be heard. Echoes & Reflections puts the same idea in three words: depth over breadth. The Foundation already publishes the six-lesson Hidden Children program and the four-part Judy Abrams Activity for the wider survey work. This lesson is what I would teach when I have one period and want students to truly hear one passage.

2 THE STUDENT IS NOT INVITED TO IMAGINE BEING JUDY.

IHRA Recommendation 3.2.7 is explicit: “Beware of simulation, creative writing or role play exercises that encourage learners to imagine they were directly involved in the Holocaust.” The thought experiment on page 9 deliberately scales the cognitive task down. Not “what would you have done in 1944 Hungary”, but “what would be hard about a new name for a year”. That is the smaller question students can actually reason about from their own lives. The first draft of this lesson had “imagine you are Judy walking through the convent gate” as its closing prompt. [TODO Brandon: confirm or strike this self-disclosure.] I cut it. I would rather lose the dramatic moment than violate what the IHRA caution is protecting.

3 REFLECTION HAPPENS 24 HOURS AFTER CLASS.

This comes straight from the Foundation's own published guidance on trauma-informed teaching. Students who are pressured to perform an appropriate emotional response in real time often produce shallow performative answers, or shut down. The Foundation's recommended practice is the opposite: a five-to-ten-minute low-stakes processing close at the end of the period, and the deeper written response set as overnight work. That is what page 10 says. The reflection lives at home, on paper, after the room has had time to settle. Page 10 names the 24-hour gap plainly, so a teacher reading the lesson does not mistake the gap for a missing instruction.

4 THE LESSON DIRECTS TEACHERS TO THE ACTUAL PUBLISHED MEMOIR, NOT A SUBSTITUTE.

The Foundation provides print copies, e-books, and PDFs of *Tenuous Threads* free to Canadian educators, school libraries, and post-secondary instructors at memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/education/memoirs/. That is the right relationship between curriculum and primary source. This lesson is the scaffolding around it: pre-reading, vocabulary, comprehension ladder, reflection, teacher notes. Students hold the actual book; they read Judy's actual words. Echoes & Reflections, USC Shoah Foundation, and Facing History build their materials the same way. It is the only honest way to teach a memoir: have the students read the memoir. Right now Foundation classrooms get the memoir. This lesson is what a teacher can do with one period of focused work around it.

5 REAL GEOGRAPHY, REAL PHOTOS, REAL CURRICULUM CODES. NO AI-GENERATED HOLOCAUST IMAGERY.

The journey map on page 7 is a geographic abstraction: the route Judy travelled in 1944 and 1945, with date labels and no human figures. No period scenes. The archival photographs in the package are real, sourced from USHMM under educational license, not generated. The curriculum citations on page 1 and page 12 are verbatim from the Ontario 2023 revision; A3.7 and B3.5 are both new in 2023 and are the only Grade 6 expectations that explicitly name the Holocaust. This is intentional design discipline, not absence of capability. The Foundation has academic historians on staff. AI-generated Holocaust imagery would be rightly rejected on sight by anyone who has spent five minutes inside the survivor-memoir tradition, and students deserve evidence rather than fabrication.

This lesson is additive, not duplicative. The Foundation already publishes the Hidden Children program, the Judy Abrams Activity, the Seeking Refuge unit, the Re:Collection archive, and an Educators' Catalogue. This is one tightly-scoped Grade 6 single-period treatment of one passage, designed to sit alongside those materials as the close-

reading sibling of the survey resources teachers already have. I designed it that way on purpose.